

The Kennedy Administration

Convinced that countries such as South Vietnam were key arenas in an ideological war between communism and freedom, John F. Kennedy was determined to support Diem's regime in its fight against the Viet Cong.

◀◀ BEFORE

Soviet rhetoric helped change Kennedy's mind about supporting a war in Vietnam.

CHANGE OF HEART

As a young senator, John F. Kennedy told the Senate in April 1954 that **no amount of military assistance** in Indochina could conquer an enemy that **had the sympathy and covert support of the people**. Kennedy later changed his mind. In particular, he was determined to counter Soviet leader Nikita Khrushchev's pledge to support communists across the globe in their wars of national liberation. The US, Kennedy promised, would ensure liberty prevailed. It would pay any price and oppose any foe to stop the spread of communism.

John F. Kennedy won the US presidency in 1960 partly on the strength of pledges to wage the Cold War more vigorously than Eisenhower, his Republican predecessor. This meant developing US capabilities to fight small-scale conflicts, known as brushfire wars, including the one in Vietnam.

As part of his bid to beef up US foreign policy, Kennedy recruited a remarkable team of advisers: Robert McNamara, the former president of Ford Motor Company, as secretary of defense; Dean Rusk, president of the Rockefeller Foundation, as the secretary of state; foreign policy expert McGeorge Bundy as Kennedy's national security adviser; and economist Walt Whitman Rostow, who became Bundy's deputy. At the suggestion of Kennedy's brother Robert, the recently retired General Maxwell Taylor became Kennedy's personal military aide.

Taylor was a military maverick, preferring "flexible response" to traditional US strategy that relied on overwhelming retaliation. He argued that it was "as necessary to deter or win quickly limited wars as to deter general wars." In his view, retaining a strong and flexible infantry was as important as possessing nuclear missiles.



Lay of the land

In September 1963, General Maxwell Taylor (second right) went to Vietnam to assess the war effort. He met with MACV commander General Paul Harkins (carrying briefcase), whose reports had painted a favorable picture of US progress.